



OFF-SIDE

Ayon Sengupta

sportstar@thehindu.co.in



FOOTBALL HAS THE WORLD, BUT BASKETBALL HAS NEW YORK

The FIFA World Cup has brought the globe to New York, but the **city's attention** is fixed on the New York Knicks and a NBA title that generations waited to see.

It is hard to ignore basketball if you are in New York these days. Even with a World Cup unfolding just across the Hudson River, the city has refused to dial down the euphoria surrounding the Knicks' first NBA title in 53 years.

For a city that measures itself through sporting moments, much like many of its American counterparts, this championship means more than a routine title triumph. It ended a wait that had stretched back to 1973, when New York last won the NBA crown. The Knicks defeated the San Antonio Spurs, the team that had denied them in the 1999 Finals, 4-1 to clinch the title on the road with a 94-90 victory in Game Five. Jalen Brunson, the face of this long-awaited revival, delivered 45 points in the decisive game and was duly named Finals MVP.

Thousands had gathered at the watch party at Plaza33, the public space outside Madison Square Garden, and the final buzzer triggered scenes of disbelief, relief and release. Strangers hugged as chants of "Let's Go Knicks" rolled through Manhattan, while blue and orange smoke engulfed a city that had waited more than half a century for this night.

The city's mayor, Zohran Mamdani, announced a ticker-tape parade through the famed Canyon of Heroes on June 18, calling it a moment generations of New Yorkers had waited for. The team will also receive the ceremonial Keys to the City, while municipal buildings across the five boroughs will be illuminated in the Knicks' blue and orange colours.

Cecile, a New York resident whose parents were not even born when the Knicks last won the title, said the

moment felt surreal. "It has been such a long wait for the city. People say New York never sleeps and we all know about the New Year countdown in Times Square, but nothing beats this spontaneous outpouring of emotions," she said.

The city's famous citizens were equally overjoyed. Director Spike Lee, the team's most recognisable courtside devotee, finally witnessed the championship he had waited decades for. Timothee Chalamet, Tracy Morgan, Jay-Z and other familiar faces were regular fixtures throughout the playoff run.

The frenzy, however, also spilled into chaos. For travelling FIFA media trying to navigate Times Square, the area became difficult to traverse as fans poured in, caught between celebration and disorder. Reports later said a few academy buses used as World Cup shuttles had been vandalised.

Football may be hosting the world, but New York is still celebrating the triumph of its hometown heroes. The FIFA World Cup has brought supporters from every continent to the region, but in sports bars, subway stations and on street corners, conversations still revolve around Brunson, the Garden and a championship that many lifelong New Yorkers feared would never arrive.

For now, the city remains suspended between two sporting spectacles. On one side of the Hudson, the World Cup is trying to capture New York's imagination. On the other, the city is still consumed by its own sporting fairy tale, one that has finally come true after 53 years.